

## **The Hardest Thing I Have Done: Volunteering During COVID-19**

The hardest thing I have ever done was volunteering as a Project Suraksha Team Member at SMIMER Hospital in Surat, India, during the peak of the COVID-19 pandemic from April to November 2020. For eight months, I immersed myself in a chaotic and emotionally taxing environment, supporting healthcare professionals, patients, and their families during an unprecedented global crisis. Witnessing the suffering of patients battling a relentless virus, coupled with the weight of my responsibilities, tested my resilience in ways I never imagined. Yet, this experience taught me profound lessons about empathy, adaptability, and the strength found in collective effort.

When the pandemic struck, I felt a deep urge to contribute to my community in Surat. At 19, freshly graduated from high school and preparing for my Bachelor's degree, I joined Project Suraksha, a social services initiative aimed at bolstering hospital operations. My role at SMIMER Hospital was multifaceted. I assisted healthcare professionals with administrative tasks—managing patient records, answering phone inquiries from frantic families, and organizing schedules amidst constant disruptions. I also ensured sanitization and hygiene protocols were strictly followed, wiping down surfaces, distributing sanitizers, and monitoring compliance in a high-stakes environment where a single oversight could escalate the spread. One of my most critical duties was distributing personal protective equipment (PPE) to medical staff, ensuring they had masks, gloves, and gowns to shield themselves from the virus they faced daily.

But the hardest part wasn't the physical exhaustion or the long hours - it was seeing the patients. Walking through the wards, I encountered individuals gasping for breath, their eyes reflecting fear and desperation. Families stood outside, separated by glass and protocols, unable to comfort their loved ones. I recall a young mother, barely older than me, pleading for updates on her husband as I relayed messages between her and the overworked nurses. Another time, I sat with an elderly man who had no visitors, holding his hand through gloved layers as he whispered about his grandchildren. Each encounter carved a deep emotional wound. The sheer helplessness I felt, knowing I could only offer small comforts amid their suffering, was overwhelming. At night, those faces haunted me, and I often cried silently, questioning if my efforts made any difference in the face of such loss.

Beyond emotional strain, the practical challenges were daunting. The hospital was a whirlwind of activity - supplies dwindled, staff were stretched thin, and protocols evolved daily. I had to adapt quickly, learning to prioritize tasks under pressure. One day, I might be

rushing PPE to an ICU ward; the next, I'd be consoling a family over the phone as they received devastating news. The unpredictability demanded resilience and a calm demeanor, even when I felt anything but calm inside. Coordinating with Project Surat, I also helped streamline resource distribution, ensuring our limited supplies reached those who needed them most. It was a crash course in crisis management, far removed from the textbooks I'd soon study at Veer Narmad South Gujarat University.

From this grueling experience, I learned three invaluable lessons. First, empathy is a powerful force. Offering a listening ear or a kind word to patients and families, even when I couldn't cure their pain, taught me that human connection can provide solace in the darkest times. I saw how my small acts—holding a hand, delivering a message—eased their burdens, however briefly, and this deepened my commitment to supporting others. Second, adaptability is essential in chaos. The pandemic's unpredictability forced me to think on my feet, whether troubleshooting supply shortages or adjusting to new safety measures. This flexibility has since shaped how I approach challenges, from academic projects to professional roles. Finally, I learned the strength of collective effort. Working alongside doctors, nurses, and fellow volunteers, I witnessed how our combined contributions - however small—built a lifeline for the community. No single person could stem the tide, but together, we made a tangible difference.

Volunteering during COVID-19 was the hardest thing I've done because it thrust me into the heart of human suffering and demanded I confront my own limits. Yet, it was also transformative. It instilled in me a resilience I didn't know I possessed and a clarity about my purpose—to use my skills in analytics and management to solve real-world problems, much like I did at SMIMER Hospital. Those eight months remain a cornerstone of my growth, reminding me that even in the toughest moments, there is strength to be found and lessons to be learned.

Below are the photos and the Certification for the volunteering:





The Lil kid from the left side is me.